incomes enjoyed in the West. The left in Eastern Europe, at first discredited by the Communist legacy, was thus gradually becoming in tune with public sentiments at home, but also aligning with the prevailing spirits in wider Europe.

On the side of the new political forces, those seeking redress have in the early days of transition made use of ‘lustration’ – the removal from office of those who had been compromised by participation in the former regime. The former East Germany is known to have been most systematic in doing this. Others followed suit, with the intensity of the process being inversely proportional to the perceived softness of the former regime in a particular country. Generally speaking, throughout Eastern Europe, lustration was only halfheartedly implemented, and soon began to run contrary to the spirits of the time too.

In some countries, the process of lustration also swept editors and journalists from their positions. Despite such measures, the return of democracy has not also meant the return of truly free and unbiased media. The advantage of ‘old boys’ in business and media allowed for survival and, ultimately, continued dominance of the left-leaning media. There was only limited room for truly new and independent media – and also few trained journalists apart from those already in the job. As the political transition continued, efforts to make the media landscape more plural and transparent began increasingly to be seen as attempts by conservative governments to control the media, as if the declared and by now legislated freedom of expression was not enough. So the media became another area where the new democratic parties and conservative activists were increasingly out of tune with prevailing expectations in Eastern European societies, but also out of tune with the way of thinking in Western Europe, where the end of redress was expected. Transition was declared as ended with the entry of these countries into the European Union, so normalisation should follow. But now it appeared that they were the new democratic parties rocking the boat of constitutional order that was supposed to be untouchable.

As we shall see in the next chapter, distortions also continued in the area of government checks and balances. Skilfully, the former Communists have discreetly been spreading doubts about parliamentary democracy at a time when in the West liberal democratic governance has been challenged by populists and autocrats due to its perceived lack of effectiveness.